

LIVE



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ITEM WISE EDITORIALS

27th WEEK



INDIA & IRAN

UPSC CSE – GS II

GS II ... EFFECT OF POLICIES AND POLITICS OF DEVELOPED AND DEVELOPING COUNTRIES ON INDIA'S INTERESTS.

4

Postscript to the proxy war

Tensions threaten to spiral between the U.S. and Iran ahead of the coming battle for southern Syria



MOHAMAD BAZZI

On June 18, a U.S. warplane shot down a Syrian regime jet after it bombed American-backed rebels in northern Syria – the first time the U.S. has downed a Syrian warplane since the start of the country's civil war in 2011. Two days later, the Pentagon announced it had shot down an Iranian-made drone in the country's south-east, where American personnel have been training anti-Islamic State fighters, and where a complex geopolitical battle is unfolding.

Since President Donald Trump took office, the U.S. military has struck the Syrian regime or its allies at least five times. Even if the Pentagon may not want to directly engage Syrian forces, or their Russian and Iranian-backed allies, there's a danger of accidental escalation, especially as various forces continue to converge on eastern and southern Syria to reclaim strategic territory from the Islamic State (IS).

Mr. Trump's willingness to use military force against Syrian President Bashar al-Assad and his chief supporters risks sparking a widening confrontation, while distracting from what Mr. Trump insists is his top priority: defeating the IS in

both Iraq and Syria. As a presidential candidate, Mr. Trump campaigned on a pledge to avoid direct U.S. involvement in the Syrian conflict. Today, he has become a major player in a regional proxy war that could determine West Asia's dynamics for decades.

The Syrian conflict has expanded into a war that involves regional and world powers – including the U.S., Russia, Iran, Turkey, Saudi Arabia, and Qatar – whose interests sometimes overlap, but at other times lead to multiple confrontations and uncomfortable alliances. Under the Obama administration, U.S. policy in Syria was focused on containing the IS, largely ignoring Mr. Assad, and keeping American allies from fighting each other.

The Iran factor

The dangers are particularly acute when it comes to Iran, which made dramatic battlefield moves of its own last month when it launched several missiles from inside Iran against IS targets in eastern Syria. Officially, Iran's Revolutionary Guards said the volley of missiles fired at Deir al Zour province was a response to a pair of attacks by IS militants in Tehran on June 7, the first time that the terrorist group had struck inside Iran.

After shooting down the Syrian jet, the Pentagon insisted it would protect the Syrian rebels it has been training and arming for more than a year to launch the assault on the IS in Raqqa, capital of its self-proclaimed caliphate. "The coal-



ition does not seek to fight Syrian regime, Russian, or pro-regime forces partnered with them, but will not hesitate to defend coalition or partner forces from any threat," the U.S. statement said. And foremost among those threats, in the eyes of the Trump administration, is Iran. While Mr. Trump has changed his mind on a number of foreign policy questions since taking office, he has been consistent in his belief that Iran poses the greatest threat to U.S. interests in West Asia.

Nowhere is Iran projecting its regional power more extensively than Syria. Since the war started, Tehran has sent billions of dollars in aid and thousands of troops and Shiite volunteers to support Mr. Assad's men. Over the past two years, Russia and Iran, along with Hezbollah and several Iraqi Shiite militias, helped the Syrian President consolidate control and regain territory he lost to Syrian rebels and foreign jihadists. In December, with intensive Russian airstrikes and Iranian ground support, his forces

recaptured the rebel-held sections of Aleppo, Syria's largest city. It was Mr. Assad's biggest victory since the war began. The next prize for the Syria government and its allies is the eastern province of Deir al-Zour, home to the country's modest oilfields. This desert expanse includes several border crossings between Syria, Iraq and Jordan – and the strategic highway connecting Damascus and Baghdad.

In recent weeks, Syrian troops, along with Hezbollah and other Shiite militias, have been moving to consolidate control over the area and to connect with Iranian-backed militias that are fighting to dislodge the IS from the Iraqi side of the border.

The Trump administration is worried that with these gains, Iran and its allies will carve out a "Shiite crescent" extending from Iran, through Iraq and Syria, and into Lebanon, where Hezbollah is the most powerful political and military force. Such a prospect looms large not only for the U.S. administration, but also its allies in the Arab world, especially Saudi Arabia.

Since taking office, Mr. Trump and his top advisers have shifted their rhetoric to reflect more explicit support for Saudi Arabia and its Sunni Arab allies, and, in turn, a harsher view of Iran. The shift was cemented during Mr. Trump's visit in May to the kingdom, which he chose as the first stop on his maiden overseas trip as President. Like his Saudi hosts, Mr. Trump

framed the problems of West Asia as due solely to Iran's belligerence and terrorism by Islamist extremist groups, despite the kingdom's destabilising activities across the region, including its ongoing catastrophic war in Yemen and its recent blockade of Qatar.

Meanwhile, Iranian officials are growing increasingly frustrated at the Trump administration's constant attacks on the July 2015 agreement Tehran signed with the U.S. and five other world powers to limit its nuclear programme in exchange for the lifting of international sanctions.

While Washington is eager to portray its latest actions in Syria as defensive measures, Mr. Assad's regime and its Iranian allies view them as an aggression, noting that the Pentagon shot down a Syrian jet in Syrian airspace.

And by flexing their military reach in Syria with a missile launch, Iran's Revolutionary Guards and other regime hardliners risk inflaming more tension with the Trump administration – tension that could boil over in the coming war for dominance of southern Syria.

There is a danger that one of the many players in this conflict could overreach and provoke a new confrontation that spirals out of control.

Mohamad Bazzi is a journalism professor at New York University and former Middle East bureau chief at *Nesuday*. He is writing a book on the proxy wars between Saudi Arabia and Iran.

THE  HINDU

Date : 7th July, 2017



TURKEY

Cyprus

Mediterranean Sea

Aleppo

SYRIA

Lebanon

Damascus

IRAQ

Israel

JORDAN

KUWAIT



PLAYERS IN SYRIA

1



Bashar Hafez al-Assad,
President, Syria

Supported by
Russia & Iran

2

**MAIN
OPPOSITION
PARTIES**

Supported by
USA, Saudi Arabia
& others

3



Islamic State



Jabhat Fateh al-Sham (JFS)
This is also known as Al-Nusra Front

They occupied substantial
areas of the country





IRAN

- Officially “Islamic Republic of Iran” also known as Persia
 - Extends from Caspian Sea to Persian Gulf and Gulf of Oman
 - One of the world’s largest proven oil reserves and natural gas reserves
 - Islamic Republic, with the concept of “Supreme Leader”
 - Population ... 8 crores (approx.)
 - Capital .. Tehran
 - Currency ... Rial
- Known for “Islamic Revolution” of 1979
 - Global leader for “Shia Muslim Sect”
 - Antagonized USA & West for the past “35 years”
 - Sanctions were lifted recently after the “historic nuclear deal” with world powers (P5+1)
 - Official language ... Persian
 - It supports Shia Militias in several countries







BARACK OBAMA & IRAN



Barack Obama,
44th U.S. President



IRAN

- 1 *During Barack Obama's time, the USA tried to improve relations with Iran much against the wishes of Sunni-led Saudi Arabia.*
- 2 *Nuclear deal with Iran was in that direction.*
- 3 *But, unpredictable Trump now taking Iran head on and siding towards Saudi Arabia and its allies.*





RECENT DEVELOPMENTS IN SYRIAN CIVIL WAR

- 1** *On June 18, US war plane shot down a Syrian regime jet after it bombed American-backed rebels in Northern Syria.*
- 2** *First time, the US has downed a Syrian war plane, since the start of the Country's civil war in 2011*
- 3** *Two days later Pentagon announced it had shot down Iranian made drone in the Country's South-east.*
- 4** *After Donald Trump took Office, US military has struck the Syrian regime or its allies at least five times.*

US policy in Syria was focussed in containing IS during Barack Obama administration largely ignoring Mr. Assad but the dynamics changed with Trump's arrival.





CHANGED CIRCUMSTANCES



- 1 Now, the target is Iran because Iran is trying to extend its power in the region.
- 2 Substantial gains were made by Syria against rebel forces as well as IS by Assad regime.
- 3 This is not acceptable to Saudi Arabia and its allies.
- 4 This may be due to the reason that there is every possibility that Shiite arc may be developed in future involving Iran, Iraq, Syria, Lebanon.





SYRIA

IRAQ

IRAN

LEBANON

Israel

JORDAN

SAUDI ARABIA

KUWAIT

TURKMENISTAN

AFGHANISTAN

n Sea

Persian Gulf

Strait of Hormuz



5

Signs of a Persian gulf

New Delhi needs to work with Tehran to resolve bilatera



HARSH V. PANT

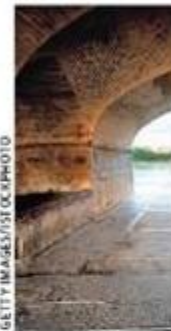
During his Id sermon delivered on June 26, Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei ended up equating the Kashmir conflict with those in Yemen and Bahrain. He is reported to have said: "Conflicts in Yemen, Bahrain, problems in all Islamic countries, are major wounds on the body of Islam. The world of Islam should explicitly support the people of Yemen, and express [its] disdain against the oppressors who've attacked the people in such horrible ways during the month of [Ramzan]... The same is true for the people of Bahrain and Kashmir: Our people can back this great movement within the world of Islam."

Though this took many observers by surprise, the Ayatollah has been talking of Kashmir for quite some time. In 2010, he had sermonised: "Helping the Palestinian nation and the besieged people of

Gaza, sympathy toward and co-operation with the people of Afghanistan, Pakistan, Iraq and Kashmir... safeguarding the unity of Muslims... and spreading awakening and [a] sense of commitment and responsibility among Muslim youth in all Islamic lands – these are great responsibilities that currently lie on the shoulders of prominent figures of the Islamic Ummah."

Politics in the Arab world

So there is nothing new in his recent statement, and New Delhi has done well not to give it too much weight. India's relations with Iran are important and the reformist regime of Hassan Rouhani is looking for a wider global engagement. The Ayatollah's statement probably reflects his country's concerns about getting regionally isolated at a time when the Donald Trump administration's hard line against Tehran seems to have emboldened Saudi Arabia and its allies to squeeze Iran out of the regional matrix. The de facto blockade of Qatar by Saudi Arabia, Egypt, Bahrain and the United Arab Emirates (UAE) after cutting off diplomatic ties last month underscores this complex reality. Qatar has been issued a 13-



GETTY IMAGES/ISTOCKPHOTO

point list of demands includes curbing diplomatic ties with Iran, severing ties with Brotherhood and Jazeera news network. It has been rejected by the UN. The Ayatollah further warned that such measures would further isolate Iran and hurt the world.

Saudi Arabia is engaged in a range of actions across the region, including Syria, Yemen, a growing hostility towards the Islamic Revolution and Tehran. It is shaping the Gulf in its own interests and instrumentally to consolidate its power. An Iranian Parliament on July

THE  HINDU

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Signs of a Persian gulf

New Delhi needs to work with Tehran to resolve bilatera



HARSH V. PANT

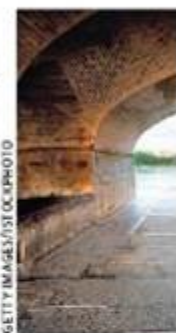
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point list of demands that includes curbing drug traffic, severing ties with Iran, and supporting Brotherhood and Jazeera news networks. Further, the measures would further isolate Iran and force it to embrace any future Saudi Arabia-led initiative across the region. Syria, Yemen, a growing hostility towards the Islamic Revolution, and Tehran's efforts to shape the Gulf in their own interests instrumentally to suit of power. An Iranian Parliament on June

SIGNS OF A PERSIAN GULF

PRESENT CONTEXT

- 1 During his Id sermon, Iran's Supreme Leader Ayatollah Ali Khamenei ended up equating the Kashmir conflict with those in Yemen and Bahrain.
- 2 Quite often, Supreme Leader of Iran raises the Kashmir issue and equates it with the problems in other Muslim countries. But the important point to note is the timing is significant as Sunni-led Arab countries Saudi Arabia, UAE, and Egypt recently imposed sanctions on Qatar.

THE  HINDU

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Black Sea

GEORGIA

ARMENIA

AZERBAIJAN

UZBEKISTAN

KYRGYZSTAN

TURKEY

TURKMENISTAN

TAJIKISTAN

an Sea

Cyprus

SYRIA

IRAQ

IRAN

AFGHANISTAN

PAKISTAN

JORDAN

EGYPT

NEPAL

Red Sea

SAUDI ARABIA

SUDAN

ERITREA

YEMEN

OMAN

Gulf of Oman

INDIA

BANGLADESH

MYANMAR (BURMA)

Arabian Sea

Bay of Bengal



INDIA - IRAN

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS



- 1** Iran is delaying the awarding of the contract for gas exploration in its Farzad B offshore field to ONGC Videsh.
- 2** India decided to decrease the volume of Iranian crude oil, it will be buying this year.
- 3** There are also news reports that Iran has signed an initial agreement for the gas field with Russian giant Gazprom.
- 4** The slow pace of the Chabahar port project has irked the Iranians.
- 5** Another important development is despite India developing the project, Iran indicated that it won't be exclusive to the country. Pakistan and China might also be invited to get involved.



CENTRAL ASIAN COUNTRIES





WHAT IS THE WAY OUT?

- 1 Hassan Rouhani was re-elected as President.
- 2 It is the utmost necessity to ensure that bilateral irritants in fostering the economic ties are resolved as early as possible.
- 3 As Donald Trump's administration is firmly appears to be sided with Saudi Arabia Administration, India should tread a balanced approach as being followed for the past several years.

The art of maintaining balance in West Asia must be continued irrespective of various global developments.



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